

Luca Looser

Curriculum vitae

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Placement Officer	Edouard Schaal

Education

2023 –	Universitat Pompeu Fabra, Ph.D. Candidate in Economics Expected completion: June 2027 Advisors: Elisa Giannone and Dávid Krisztián Nagy
2022 – 2023	Universitat Pompeu Fabra, MRes in Economics, Finance and Management
2021 – 2022	Barcelona School of Economics, MSc in Economics (PhD Track)
2020 – 2021	London School of Economics, MSc in Economics
2015 – 2019	University of St. Gallen, B.A. in Economics
2017 – 2018	Keio University, Exchange Program

Research fields

Primary:	Macro Development
Secondary:	Economic Geography, Family Economics

Research experience

2024 –	Short-Term Consultant for Tatjana Kleineberg, World Bank
2023 – 2024	Research Assistant for Prof. Paula Bustos, Universitat Pompeu Fabra

Teaching experience

Undergraduate

2023	Microeconomics I, Universitat Pompeu Fabra
2023	International Economics I, Universitat Pompeu Fabra

Professional experience

2019 – 2020	Intern, Inflation Forecasting Unit, Swiss National Bank
2018 – 2019	Student Assistant for Statistical Analysis, University of St. Gallen

Research visits

Aug.–Sep. 2026	Washington University in St. Louis Host: Francisco Buera
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Presentations

2026	UPF Applied Lunch; CREi International Lunch; 8th QMUL Economics and Finance Workshop; 2nd EUI ECO PhD Workshop; HEC Economics PhD Conference; XXIX Workshop on Dynamic Macroeconomics; 20th North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association*; LAEF Growth, Inequality, and Macro Development Conference*; OxDev 2026*; WashU Macro Breakfast;
2025	BSE Jamboree; CREi International Lunch; 20th End-of-Year Conference of Swiss Economists Abroad
2023 – 2024	CREi International Lunch

Research

Job Market Paper

The Family Geography of Structural Change

Structural transformation reallocates workers across sectors and places, but these choices also reshape the family networks inherited by later generations. I study this feedback during U.S. structural transformation from 1880 to 1950. I construct economy-wide extended family networks by linking full-count censuses across generations and space. Family connections are directional: sector-employed relatives increase entry into the same sector, relatives at origin discourage migration and relatives at destination sustain migration links. Schooling weakens dependence on inherited sector connections. I embed these channels in a dynamic spatial model in which workers inherit family ties and create new ones through their own sector and location choices. Family channels account for 15.23% of the recovered agriculture-to-manufacturing entry barrier in 1880, and equalizing the inherited geography of horizontal ties raises the 1950 manufacturing share by 1.02 percentage points. The dynamic effects differ sharply across policies. School expansion is amplified by family capital already in place, especially in places lagging in structural transformation. Migration initially encounters inherited local attachments but, as workers move, creates destination networks that amplify later reallocation. Structural transformation therefore inherits a social geography and, through the choices it induces, progressively reshapes it.

Working Papers

Unequal Global Convergence

with Shoumitro Chatterjee, Elisa Giannone, Tatjana Kleineberg and Kan Kuno

We revisit the role of structural transformation in regional convergence using a new global dataset covering more than 1,500 regions in over 90 countries since 1980. Regional convergence declines over time and stalls in the most recent decade despite substantial remaining spatial inequality. This decline is associated with structural transformation toward high-skill services, which are more geographically concentrated than agriculture, manufacturing or other services. A spatial equilibrium model shows how the shift toward high-skill services can reinforce agglomeration and weaken regional convergence.

The Intergenerational Benefits of a Temporary Negative Shock: Evidence from Import Restrictions in Thailand

with Chanont Banternghansa and Elisa Giannone

We exploit a temporary, sector-specific import restriction in Thailand to study the long-run consequences of a short-lived negative demand shock. Exposed shrimp farmers experience large initial income losses, but the adjustment persists after the direct shock has disappeared: affected households remain more likely to leave shrimp production and accumulate assets in new sectors. The consequences differ across generations and adjustment margins. Producers who remain in the sector benefit as competitors exit, while younger members of households that reallocate experience improvements in education. The results show how a temporary shock can generate persistent sectoral reallocation and intergenerational effects.

Work in Progress

Inheriting Geography: Marriage and the Intergenerational Transmission of Spatial Opportunity

Using linked complete-count U.S. censuses from 1880 to 1950, I study how marriage merges spouses' extended-family geographies and how these new spatial connections shape household location and the next generation. Marriage substantially expands the family's geographic reach, and within-family comparisons show that spouses' family geographies shift where couples settle. Children primarily inherit the geography realized by their parents rather than independently exploiting the full set of destinations created by the marriage.

Grants and fellowships

2026	STEG-BSE Research Grant
2021 – 2023	GPEFM PhD Track Fellowship, Universitat Pompeu Fabra

Professional service

IT and language skills

Programming

Stata, MATLAB, Python, R, L^AT_EX

Languages

German (native), Italian (native), English (fluent), French (intermediate), Spanish (B2), Japanese (A2)

References

Elisa Giannone (Advisor)

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Manuel García-Santana

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Dávid Krisztián Nagy (Advisor)

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Francisco Buera

Washington University in St. Louis

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